actions, since it is the institutions that are created for the states, and not the other way around. […] The problem, however, is not that we walk our path to integration too slowly and should rapidly accelerate this process.'

This has for some time been the position of Poland and to a large extent the entire Višegrad Four. But the Polish Prime Minister is less explicit on how the European common good can be secured via a different path and only vaguely speaks about 'returning to the principles underlying the European Union', rather than 'strengthening the institutional superstructure'. So he does not explain how exactly the EU, with a lesser supranational structure, can actively work against Russian ambitions. Interestingly, he also does not develop further the reference to the principles and values.

So the challenge of the so-called 'illiberal Europe' (despite some gestures of goodwill on the side of Warsaw) in the region remains, perhaps above all in Hungary. There some concessions have been made to Brussels' demands with regard to the rule of law, but the country failed to fit fully into the frame of the European response to the war in Ukraine. Hungary is also taking a much more lenient approach to China, which some would see as compatible with the alleged authoritarian tendencies in Hungary (and others as plain pragmatism). At the same time, the Polish attitude to Russia and China is exactly the opposite. There is also no sympathy for the Russian traditionalist narrative, despite the strength of Polish Catholicism. In fact, in a July 2022 meeting, the Polish and Hungarian Prime Ministers publicly acknowledged their differences.

Whatever we may think of illiberal tendencies in Eastern Europe – and we should certainly be worried about them – they do raise issues about what the root causes of such attitudes are. After all, similar underlying reasons for the rise of populism exist in Western Europe. But nowhere can populism, fundamentalism or worse be won over by a judgemental approach, cancelling out dissenting opinions, and by denying conservative views due legitimacy. One of the possible ways to confront social conservatism in its extreme forms (both East and West) should be by redressing the grievances heard by their representatives and voters. And these are and will continue to be many, according to Charles Dumas, 'from job displacement by hi-tech, from E[uro]A[rea] imbalances, from inequality of income and wealth, from structural weakness and continued debt